

# EL07 Comments

## Public Service Provision and Electoral Behaviour — EPSS 2026

Frederik Hjorth  
Associate Professor, Ph.D.  
[fghjorth.github.io](https://fghjorth.github.io)



## 1 Kölzer & Kuberka

## 2 de la Cuesta et al.

# General comments

- Comprehensive literature review — deep command of the public-service-provision and geography-of-resentment literatures
- Impressive technical work: novel geocoded data on rail reactivations (644 km of reopened track)
- Top-tier estimation throughout (staggered DiD, Callaway–Sant’Anna)
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# Motivation & contribution

- Motivation is framed *negatively*: retrenchment hurts → maybe reversal helps. A convoluted route to the question
- Lead instead with the positive case: many argue investment in local services can *curb* resentment and far-right support — put those arguments up front
- The (excellent) review blurs the specific contribution: Heddesheimer, Hilbig & Wiedemann (2024) already show infrastructure investment reduces AfD support and strengthens incumbents
- How is this different? The *type* of investment differs — but make that argument explicitly



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# The social-connectivity mechanism

- Your social mechanism: rail *“increases the social connectivity of residents through routine exposure to urban environments... weakening the dense homophilic ties... through which place-based resentments are locally reproduced”*
- Original and interesting — but a strong claim: prospective far-right voters ride into cities, encounter urban/multicultural life, and update attitudes
- Either retrench from it, or double down with much stronger evidence on this positive causal process
- The moderator you use to test it — direct connection to an urban centre — is plausibly a *material* benefit too. Does it really adjudicate material vs. social?

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# Composition vs. attitude change

- You cite evidence that rail connections change local population trends
- Could the estimated effects then be driven by *compositional* change rather than attitude change among residents?
- If so, what bias does that introduce for your interpretation? Worth a direct reflection

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## Inference & a figure note

- Multiple comparisons: multiple outcomes  $\times$  levels of government  $\times$  moderators
- You report “*all 88 interaction estimates*” (Tables B1–B2); a key significant result is itself an interaction
- With this many tests, the base rate for “significance” far exceeds 5% — needs discussion / adjustment
- Figure 2 (lovely): the dropped municipalities (71 active-endpoint cases) still appear as *treated* in the final panel — clarify against the verbal explanation

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- *“Whether these findings travel to multi-party proportional systems is an open question”* – you take it on
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- Main concern: the 2015 fragmentation is treated as an exogenous shock to sorting
- Exogenous to the individual voter — but *endogenous to the system*. Sorting and fragmentation co-evolve; one is not a shock to the other
- And there is little movement around 2015 anyway: “no aggregate structural break”; a Chow test finds no break in  $D$  or Moran's  $I$
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- Suggestion: pick one *preferred* outcome measure, relegate the others to robustness
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- From Sec. 5.5 the paper pivots to partisan *realignment* (changing social bases of the parties) — genuinely interesting, but unsigned
- Given the framing, how does this answer the *sorting* question? Set it up earlier and connect it explicitly
- Mind the causal language. p. 18: “*immigration reshapes local political competition by activating right-leaning voters even when immigrants themselves do not vote*” — strong for a municipal panel
- Sec. 5.6 (SDM): “*a municipality’s partisan lean is increasingly shaped by its neighbours’ lean, net of local demographics*” — strong for spatial autocorrelation. Temper both

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